

Serious Metaphysics Group

Michaelmas 2026

The *Serious Metaphysics Group* hosts speakers on a wide array of topics within theoretical philosophy, broadly construed. It is currently run by Owen Griffiths (oeg21@cam.ac.uk) and Matthew McClure (mwgm2@cam.ac.uk). Meetings are 90 minutes long and consist of a 45-minute presentation followed by a 45-minute Q&A. All are welcome and no registration is necessary.

Time: Wednesdays during term (from week 1), 16.00–17.30.

Location: Room 142, 1st floor, Raised Faculty Building.

14 October. Michael Potter (Cambridge)

Title. *Some errors in Kripke's Naming and necessity*

21 October. Ari Deller (Cambridge)

Title. *What's wrong with just asking whether AI can do human things?*

Abstract. Could AI be creative? Is it capable of friendship? Could it be trustworthy? At first glance, these seem like important and tractable questions. Scholars in the philosophy of AI seem to think so; a whole academic sub-industry is devoted to taking valorised human notions and asking whether they might be extended to artificial intelligence.

Here, I'll argue that these projects are confused in at least two ways. For one thing, the questions do not track value in the way they may seem to. For another, they face endemic problems of unresolvability.

The aim of this talk is to diagnose where these projects go wrong and offer an alternative way of conducting scholarship which might capture their spirit. Where current projects attempt to extend the content of concepts and practices *as they apply to humans*, I argue that it would be more fruitful to take a functional approach to our concepts and practices. We should work out what valuable function our concepts and practices play, and then ask how AI might maximise what the relevant concepts and practices aim at.

28 October. Timothy Williamson (Oxford)

Title. *Essence and illusion*

Abstract. The talk will be an updated version of my critique of Kit Fine's argument in his seminal paper 'Essence and Modality' against modal theories of essentiality. I'll argue that the key verdicts on examples to which he appeals are the products of a psychological heuristic that gives incorrect results in similar cases, and discuss his response to my original critique.

4 November. Robert Trueman (York)

Title. *Open to the facts*

Abstract. The *identity theory of truth* is motivated by the compelling idea that thought reaches right out to the world. This is strikingly similar to the idea that *naïve realists* use to motivate their own position, but, in their version, it is perception, not thought, that reaches out to the world. I will argue that there are strong internal pressures within naïve realism that push towards the identity theory; however, when we combine naïve realism with the identity theory in the way that I will recommend, it becomes indistinguishable from a certain kind of *representationalism*.

11 November. Derek Matravers (Open/Cambridge)

Title. *More on the ‘representation/confrontation’ distinction*

Abstract. There is an important distinction between engaging with the world directly and engaging with it via some other channel. This distinction is not well-marked in ordinary language: ‘face-to-face’ versus ‘via a representation’ comes somewhere close. In this talk I will attempt to clarify this distinction and explore some areas in which it plays a role including the philosophy of fiction and, as I will mention briefly, the philosophy of mind. My talk also helps clarify Kendall Walton’s philosophical project.

18 November. David Plunkett (Dartmouth)

Title. *Topic continuity, realism, and the objects of philosophical inquiry*

N.B. This is joint work between Prof Plunkett and Tristram McPherson (Ohio State).

25 November. Joanna Odrowaz-Sypniewska (Warsaw)

Title. *Defining lying*

Abstract. In recent years, we’ve witnessed a surge in attempts to demonstrate that the traditional definition of lying (according to which you lie iff you say something you believe to be false with the intention of deceiving your audience) is inadequate. People invent more and more complex scenarios supposedly showing, e.g., that you don’t need to say something you believe to be false: it is enough if you imply or presuppose it; or that you don’t have to intend to deceive your audience: you may lie even if they know that what you’re saying is false.

In my talk, I’m going to argue that instead of trying to invent further scenarios or quarreling over the existing ones, we should go back to the idea put forward by Coleman & Kay (1981). They claim that ‘lie’ is a prototype concept and suggest three prototypical properties of lies. Their idea has so far been largely ignored in the recent debate on how lying should be defined, but I’m going to suggest that it is well worth revisiting. I’ll argue that treating these properties as prototypical rather than as necessary and sufficient conditions allows us to accommodate the

contested cases and explain why constructing further convoluted scenarios is a pointless enterprise. I'll also argue against interpreting 'lie' as a dual-character concept.

2 December. Tatiana Barkovskiy (Cambridge)

Title. *Embodied mind and 'porous (dis)embodiment' in contemplative philosophy*

Abstract. Embodied cognition is the idea that cognition is constituted by sensory and bodily processes and that the mind is therefore shaped by the whole body, tying thinking to one's physical experience. I show how the writings of contemplative philosophers anticipate this idea. Focusing on the medieval mystic Mechthild of Magdeburg, I introduce the concept of 'porous (dis)embodiment' as referring to discourse that invokes the vocabulary of traditional, Cartesian ontological dualism (positing a fundamental distinction between material substance and immaterial substance) – only to undermine it by describing sensory aspects and experiences of the immaterial soul. As Mechthild affirms, "I do not know how to write, nor can I, unless I see with the eyes of my soul and hear with the ears of my eternal spirit and feel in all the parts of my body the power of the Holy Spirit". As she adds, God's "sublime sweetness permeates one's body and one's soul". I examine (1) the tension between Mechthild's discussions of 'spiritual eyes' and 'spiritual ears' versus 'eyes of the body', 'earthly senses', 'fleshy ears' and (2) her accounts of embodied experiences of the divine. I argue that (3) her vocabulary asserts a specific – serious – metaphysics (rather than being merely rhetorical and devotional), where she treats sensory experience as a feature of the soul's mode of being, and bodily experience as an epistemically necessary condition for knowing.